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To the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award Selection Committee,

It is a true pleasure to enthusiastically nominate Christian Gerard Capuno for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. As a professor in the Department of Molecular, Cell, and Developmental Biology (MCDB) with 25 years of teaching experience at UCLA, I have mentored many TAs. Christian stands out as a rare talent. He is comfortably within the top 5% of educators I have worked with during my career.

Christian served as my TA for MCDB 138, Developmental Biology, a core course that challenges students to understand how a complex organism arises from a single-cell fertilized egg. The material is demanding, requiring students to synthesize knowledge from genetics, cell biology and molecular biology to grasp complex morphogenic events. TAs are an integral part of this course, as they are responsible for leading discussion sessions where they review lecture concepts, clarify difficult material and facilitate deep-dive discussions of five primary scientific papers.

Christian's teaching effectiveness is best reflected in the overwhelming praise from his students. At the end of the quarter, Christian received a perfect overall teaching rating of 9 out of 9. The written feedback was universally glowing, with students frequently describing him as an "amazing TA" and emphasizing that they learned a tremendous amount specifically from his discussion sections. These formal evaluations mirror the personal feedback I received throughout the term; in my own conversations with his students, they spoke of him with genuine gratitude and admiration for his dedication to their success.

Christian's warmth and innovative pedagogy were central to this success. He utilized a "flipped-classroom" approach to lead high-level journal-club discussions, bringing a deep expertise in paper analysis to the group. To build a welcoming community, he played music during pre-class periods and used Google Form check-ins to invite "self-disclosure" from students, sharing updates about his own life and research to break down the traditional barriers between instructor and student. This supportive atmosphere effectively mitigated the "fear of failure," making students feel safe enough to participate and ask questions even when they weren't sure of the answer.

Beyond his classroom excellence, Christian proved to be a selfless leader and a true team player. During the Fall 2025 quarter, he was the only member of our three-person TA team with prior experience. He mentored his fellow TAs with incredible generosity, sharing his materials and strategies to ensure the entire team functioned smoothly and efficiently.

Christian is an outstanding candidate who embodies the spirit of the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. He is not only a brilliant instructor but a kind and dedicated mentor who has left a lasting impact on our students. I recommend him with my highest and most enthusiastic praise.

Sincerely,



Jau-Nian Chen, Ph.D.

My experiences as an instructor have yielded some of the most rewarding experiences of my graduate career thus far. The DTA award for teaching assistants recognizes individuals who demonstrate exceptional pedagogical practices and undergraduate mentorship; through my students, I've been encouraged to seek this award. Through the teaching artifacts (TAs) included within my application, I hope to demonstrate to the selection committee these same principles and how they've been put into practice. In TA: Teaching Footage, I break a student's question down regarding a particular technique and its data presentation, taking a 10x7 grid of pluses-and-minuses into a simple breakdown of what the investigators are seeking to accomplish, as well as a breakdown of the authors' constructs. Furthermore, I include class footage in which I seek to contextualize the authors' findings and provide a rationalization for why we observe the data we do, and simultaneously encourage student participation. Through some of my teaching appointments, I was also responsible for constructing weekly quizzes set on testing scientific comprehension / figure analysis–to accomplish this, I would pull figures from publications which illustrate course-related concepts, but in novel/unfamiliar contexts. In TA: Quizzes, #1, I pose a question asking students to evaluate cortical tissue samples, which may appear complex, but in actuality requires only a cursory understanding of immunofluorescence (i.e., identifying differences in colors and patterns). These kinds of questions are intentional: by forcing students to confront what they perceive to be difficult questions, then realize they are in fact properly-equipped to tackle it, they build confidence in their own skills. The same can be said in #2, which is a detail-oriented question that tests whether students fully understand the logic of interpreting a co-immunoprecipitation, or if they've merely gotten accustomed to reading blots thoughtlessly. It asks students to determine potential interactions between a protein and three others, but the specific blot combinations are misleading at first glance; only a discriminating eye will identify the blots which actually indicate these interactions. #3 details a question given in the latter half of the quarter, in which students are not only asked to interpret data, but to form an opinion and support their argument. Through this gradual buildup, often informed by Bloom's taxonomy, and accompanied by detailed feedback and constant support, students leave my classroom both with the technical knowledge, as well as the confidence to succeed in science.

I believe my teaching style is strongly suited to the flipped-classroom style of upper-division discussions; this is evidenced through TA: Discussion Slides items a-e, which depict technically complex figures or phenomena and pair them with combinations of analogies to aid student understanding, and guiding questions to hammer home the medical/physiological significance of the mechanism/system. For example, a. asks students to compare two patterns, then underpins the functional consequences of their non-equivalency, which is their nonviability for medical implantation; I used the analogy of attempting to build a car, which is described in greater detail within the TA. Likewise, item e. illustrates highly condensed lecture topics that lay out the full system, all its constituent pieces, as well as its function and consequences if disrupted. This allows students a bird's-eye view of these phenomena and encourages the "network" organization of their knowledge. Beyond core didactic strategies, however, I find the environment and relationship with my students to be equally as important for fostering effective learning. To that end, I include both academic and non-academic prompts within my students' weekly attendance forms, which are excerpted in TA: Google Forms. The academic prompts allow me to gauge my students' mastery of the material and keep an eye out for struggling

students, while the non-academic prompts provide opportunities for self-disclosure; I've found that students who are willing to share mundane things in their lives, by building this open and conversational dynamic, are more willing to share more course-relevant aspects–such as admitting when they're struggling, or openly engaging during class. Through these forms I also solicit regular feedback, allowing me to place additional weight on effective strategies and address shortcomings particular to each class. Overall, I believe I have performed as an effective mentor and educator, informed by student requests that I TA for them again, as well as their SET responses, a number of which are excerpted in TA: SET Surveys. Upon seeing these responses, as well as how many students were willing to support my nomination, I can only hope they know I enjoyed being their TA as much as they enjoyed being my students.

As a scientist–and that is to say, as a learner and student–I conceptualize knowledge as a network, and I value its application equally, if not more so than retention alone. To learn is to not only establish new nodes of information, but also connections, and to grasp the dynamic relationships between each. To trickle water drops into a growing pool, and to understand how each ripple affects another. To learn well is equally composed of grasping the information before you as it is of conceptualizing the underlying heuristics of learning itself–to learn *how* to learn, even in the absence of a structured didactic environment. That, to me, is the crystallization of knowledge; but it is another feat entirely to be trained to employ that network well–and that, to me, is what I conceptualize to be the purpose of teaching. In this field of scientific thinkers, of future physicians and biologists, we acknowledge our students as individuals we hope to one day greet as peers and colleagues, even successors; the efforts we place into their education is as much to our benefit as it is theirs, for the enrichment of the scientific community of tomorrow. Moreover, I often see myself in them: a kid from a no-name country town, still too naive to even grasp what he doesn't yet know, unsure if he has a place here–but driven by an unwavering love of science and learning, and a deep commitment to doing something good for the world. I also have had students acknowledge the reverse: that they see themselves in me, especially as a person of color living with chronic illness, thriving in these spaces. I hope to instill an admiration for the intricate beauty and wonder of life by the time they leave my classroom; I firmly believe that the scientific underpinnings of our world do not detract from its beauty–rather, they are a component of it.

As an educator, I center the logic above all else; these techniques are simply a means to an end to accomplish *this* goal; these anatomical and physiological phenomena emerged and remain today to accomplish *this* function. Once the schema is firmly established, the pieces themselves can be switched out as needed: *"Signaling-induced calcium releases vesicles from the egg which further the process of fertilization. Much in the same way, action potential-induced calcium mobilizes neurotransmitter vesicles in neurons."* More than homology and conserved mechanisms, centering the underpinning logic allows students to intuit the "why" behind different processes, allowing rote memorization to fall to the wayside. It's akin to breaking down a physics equation, allowing students to derive the terms based on their understanding of the system rather than simply remembering a set of abstract variables. "*Linear torque is a product of applied force and its distance to the fulcrum; this is the functional principle behind a crowbar.*" The same holds true for biological principles: "*Hox genes act as transcription factors, and establish themselves into patterned gradients. Different combinations along that gradient activate different genes in specific regions, setting up the overall body plan."* My strategy is not to simplify, but merely demystify; I have found that students are more than capable of grasping the jargon, so long as they retain sight of the overarching logic–so long as the words we use carry meaning to them. The goal, then, is to connect our jargon to simpler, core purposes, and build from there; much like scientific writing, I utilize a "one step back, two

steps forward" approach, circling back to prior content and drawing connections to new material, solidifying how this new information sits within an informational meshwork rather than a daisy-chain of assorted facts.

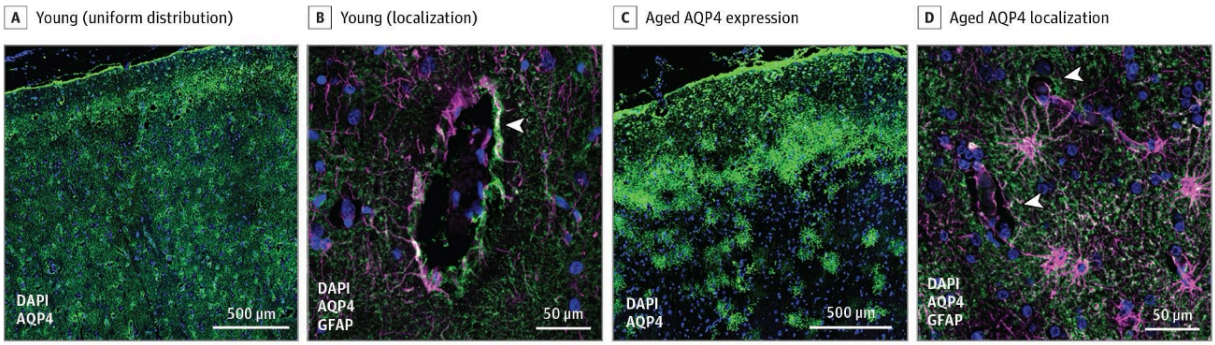
To that end, I favor a flipped-classroom structure, and center a hierarchy of development to maintain an environment of mutual respect i.e., *"if you'd like to learn, I'm here to teach–but I expect you to take this seriously."* Students overwhelmingly agree to this social contract; they grasp that I won't waste their time if they don't waste mine, and that they'll get as much as they give. On the day-to-day, I play music quietly during pre-class and active discussion periods, and I have students fill out attendance forms which include a combination of content check-ins *(what material did you find confusing / what was the hardest part of this paper?, etc.)*, tidbits on things going on in my own life (interesting happenings, research updates, etc.), and optional self-disclosure prompts for students to share more about themselves. These prompts cultivate a welcoming and conversational environment–I believe that if students feel comfortable sharing small things, they'll be more willing to share bigger ones: to admit when they're confused, to share with others, and volunteer answers when they're unsure. This supportive atmosphere also mitigates fear of failure, which in turn boosts engagement/participation, and therefore learning. Academically, the course content check-ins let me keep an eye out for students who are struggling and may need additional support, as well as to partially tailor my sections to the collective weak points of each class.

My proximal goal as an educator is for students to achieve proficiency with their material; but my larger goal is to prepare students to operate within the scientific world, to stand on their own two feet, trust their own reasoning–and, I think, most importantly, to be willing to venture forward, even if they're not fully confident that they may be right. Too many students abstain from participating out of fear of being wrong, and it is not conducive to an effective career in science. Science is a field of doubt–its practitioners must be willing and able to take steps into the dark, so long as they remain rationally founded. By developing strong relationships with students, regularly checking in, and providing my own detailed feedback and personal perspectives, I can confidently cultivate their knowledge base, confidence, and love of learning. Above all, I hope to be an example, especially to students from backgrounds like mine: *yes, you too, can succeed here.*

The following are questions and figures taken from weekly quizzes I created as a TA for MCDB 144. The purpose of these quizzes is to apply learned technical skills regarding common laboratory techniques and data analysis / scientific comprehension, with particular emphasis on understanding the underlying principles rather than context-specific rote memorization; to that end, I would generate questions from publications that used course concepts or techniques in novel/unfamiliar contexts; although a potentially steep learning curve, students strongly expressed gratitude by the end of the term, citing that these kinds of questions significantly strengthened their understanding of the material and helped them correct misconceptions.

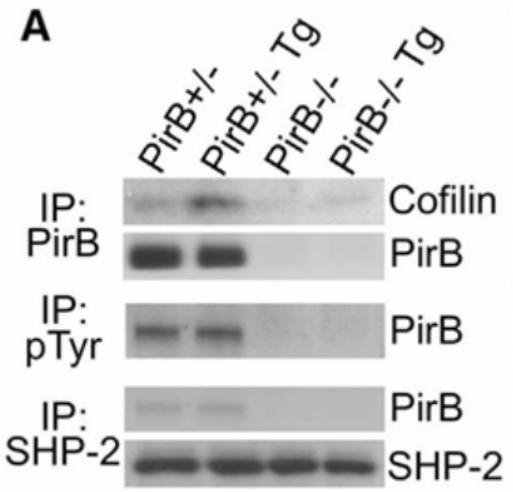
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1. This figure represents immunofluorescence staining of a human cortical cross section. (DAPI in blue, AQP4 in green, GFAP in magenta). Consider panel A and C, evaluate the change in AQP4 expression and localization between young and aged samples. Does the structure of the brain remain uniform? Bonus: Consider panel B and D, with white arrows representing a lumen. Describe the localization of AQP4 on the lumen between young and aged samples.



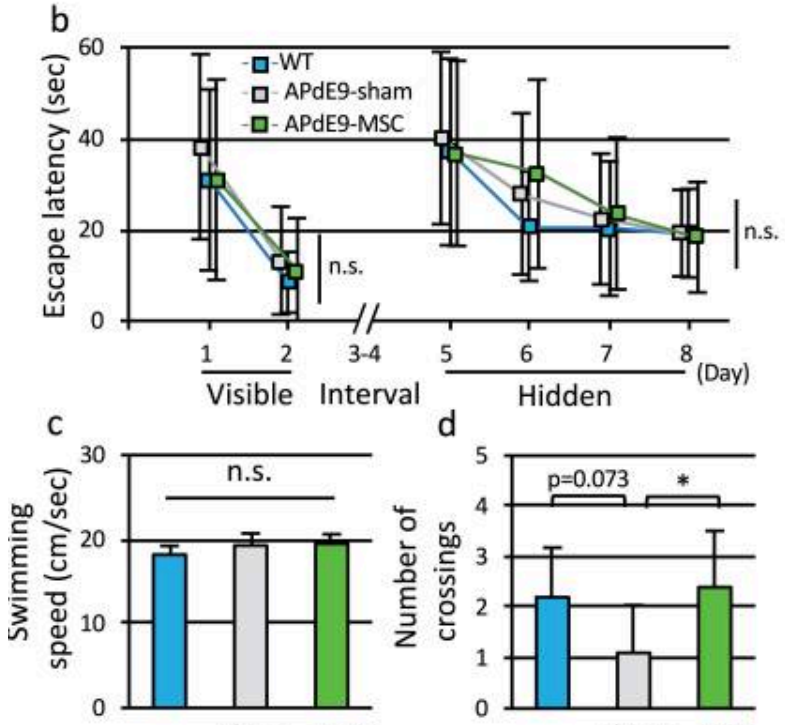
While this question is filled with molecular biology jargon, upon second glance, it becomes apparent that all this question is asking is for students to “spot the difference” between the two conditions, between localization (color density) and expression (color intensity). Making students recognize these techniques as complicated means to simple ends encourages them to grasp the underlying logic of each technique (in this case, immunofluorescence) and therefore find these questions less intimidating going forward, now that they know what is “really” being asked of them.

2a. Hao is performing IPs + a Western blot to determine whether the protein PirB associates with Cofilin, phosphotyrosine (pTyr), or SHP-2.
b. Describe whether or not wildtype PirB binds cofilin, pTyr, or SHP-2, and if so, which protein it binds best. Additionally, one of these three proteins also serve as an experimental control for the Western blot-- which one?
c. Hao also wants to know whether using a mutant form (Tg) of PirB changes its binding affinities to these proteins. Does it? If so, which protein(s), and how do the binding affinities change?

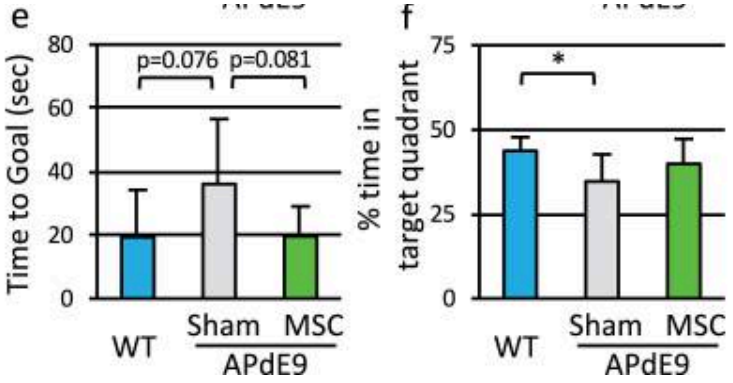


These questions are written to perhaps seem intimidating, but ultimately require only a simple application in practice; however, they require attention to detail, which in turn requires a student to understand when and where to apply a concept, not just to use it blindly. For example, this question asks about potential complexing between PirB and cofilin, pTyr, or SHP-2. Thus, students should look at the blots indicating a combination of PirB and one of the aforementioned three. Some students reported SHP-2 as having the strongest interaction, because they observed the largest blot; but that blot is the magnitude of SHP-2 presence given SHP-2 targeting (IP: SHP-2), which does not answer the question. The complex between SHP-2 and PirB, the band immediately above, is actually the weakest out of the three. Questions such as these help develop a true understanding of how co-immunoprecipitation works, as well as how to read their data; to that end, students are graded to a specific rubric describing those points and receive detailed feedback on where they went wrong / how to improve, as seen here:

"[the question] asks whether PirB binds best to cofilin, pTyr, or SHP-2. PirB has a dark band because it's a stain against itself, meaning it can't be bound to itself. Same principle that lets SHP-2 IP + SHP-2 Western serve as loading control, because you know it's going to be there so you can quantify how much. Overall, PirB binds pTyr best (compare the 1st, 3rd, and 4th rows under the wt PirB column-- aka IP PirB blotting against cofilin, IP pTyr blotting against PirB, and IP SHP-2 blotting against PirB. In all three of these you're testing for a complex between PirB and one of the three proteins). [c]: The main bars to look at are wt PirB (PirB +/-) and mutant PirB (PirB Tg). Between these two, the only change is in the cofilin band when IP'ing against PirB, which tells us that the Tg form of PirB binds cofilin better than the wt. The last two columns really only function as control groups."



3. *Chien-Mu is an undergraduate research assistant in the Tuffington Lab, where he's helping a graduate student investigate whether transplanting mesenchymal stem cells (MSCs) via tail vein injection in a mouse model of Alzheimer's Disease (APdE9) can help ameliorate symptoms of cognitive decline and memory loss. Above are trials taken from a Morris Water Maze (MWM) behavioral assay,*



where mice are initially trained on the location of a hidden platform in opaque water (b), then after a time delay are tested on their ability to remember the platform's location (hippocampal-dependent memory) after being placed in the chamber with the platform now absent. Subjects' memory is operationalized as # of times the mouse crosses the original platform's location, latency to reach the original platform location, and time spent in the general quadrant of the original platform (d-f).

a: Based on the above data, would you assert that MSC implantation corrected for symptoms of AD? Qualify your confidence in this technique by using data from the figures, both for and against your argument, then conclude why you picked the position you did.

b: Chien-Mu has some concerns about his graduate student's protocol. He notes that post-transplantation, all mice are given a regular regimen of Cyclosporine A (CsA), an immunosuppressant, to prevent graft-vs-host disease (implant rejection). He remembers that AD pathology has an immunological / neuroinflammatory component-- does this pose a potential confound that he should raise to his graduate student, or is this controlled for as part of the experimental design? Why or why not?

Quiz questions are often built in a manner building upwards through the use of increasingly complex questions on the same premise, following Bloom's Taxonomy. Firstly, to allow students to familiarize themselves with the figures, they are simply asked to identify trends and draw conclusions. To accomplish this, however, they are required to explicitly cite specific parts of the figure to demonstrate how it supports their conclusion, which accomplishes the proximal goal of having students apply known concepts to unfamiliar contexts and successfully reason through them. Often, and more so as the term progressed, the latter half of the question requires the student to take their own position, as evidenced here. Now it is no longer sufficient to be able to regurgitate data; they must be able to qualify and evaluate it for themselves. For questions such as these, there is no one right answer; students receive full credit as long as they can make a logically sound argument and fully back it up with evidence from the figures, and to examine the relative pros and cons of various experimental design conditions. This accomplishes my more long-term goal: preparing these students to operate within the scientific world, to stand on their own two feet and trust their own critical reasoning skills, and I think, most importantly, to be willing to venture forward, even if they're not fully confident that they may be right. Too many students abstain from participation out of fear of being wrong, and it is not conducive to an effective career in science. Science is a field of doubt; its practitioners must be willing and able to take shots into the dark, so long as they are still rationally founded.

Selected Student Feedback (Google Forms)

Attached are select student responses from their weekly attendance forms, which allow me to both establish a strong working relationship and conversational environment with my students, build trust by hearing about events going on in their lives and share events going on in my own life, and academically, to accurately gauge students' mastery of the material and confidence in their skills while also being able to regularly solicit feedback regarding topics they struggled on or would like me to cover in greater depth / actively track their growth, which allows me to both tailor future sections toward what each specific section needs, but also to know quite early when students are struggling so that I might offer additional guidance and support.

Tab 1 is a mid-quarter optional feedback form, including responses on what students find to be most helpful, the topics they struggle with and would like additional practice on, check-ins on how they've adapted their study techniques since beginning the course, as well as anything in particular that I might be able to do to help them learn more robustly. Students report the strong relationship and welcoming environment with their TA (myself) has made them significantly more willing to go out on a limb and attempt to answer questions they wouldn't normally (i.e. less fear of failure, more willing to venture and grow, cell K10 "*feels low pressure to ask questions or be wrong, I like discussing the difficult papers*") while being complemented by robust understanding of the course content itself and the ability to effectively communicate core principles (cell L15, "*I think he is doing great as a TA! He doesn't make the discussion boring while giving us really helpful explanations of figures we have never seen prior to reading the papers we are assigned. Also a really chill person and makes the class a nice, chill learning environment (especially since it's at 8am).*")

The following tabs are a selection of weekly attendance responses, demonstrating the combination of both academic check-ins to ensure no students are left behind in addition to some form of optional self-disclosure prompt to let students open up and get into a conversational mood at the start of each class, which in turn leads to more student engagement during the actual discussion periods.

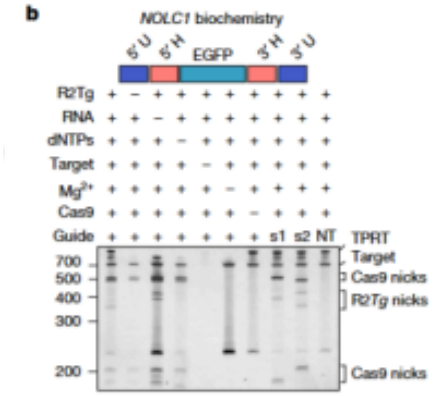
Lastly, the final tab (F138 W10), cell F30: *"thanks so much for all your help and support this quarter! I really appreciate your clarity, patience, and enthusiasm. You made the class enjoyable and engaging. Grateful to have had you as a TA :)"* and Mid-Quarter Feedback, cell B17: "*The weekly quizzes have been helpful for reinforcing key skills on paper analysis—they're manageable and a good way to stay on track with the material. I also appreciate the effort you put into engaging us during discussion, especially when you check in to see if we're following along or have questions."* – both of these student responses I believe accurately represent the efficacy of the strategies I've employed.

Linked below is a five-minute teaching footage clip that was recorded as part of an LS 495 assignment.

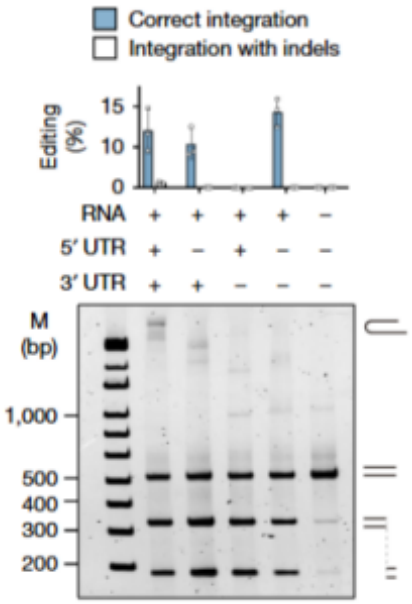
[Teaching Footage]

Course Number and Name: MCDB 144 - Molecular Biology of Cellular Processes

Purpose: Group discussion and review of this paper: https://www.nature.com/articles/s41586-025-08877-4 , Reprogramming site-specific retrotransposon activity to new DNA sites.



a. The student's first question pertains to panel 4b, which describes a "biochemical primer assay" and what that means. They then ask for clarification on how to properly interpret these data. I explain that this depicts the retrotransposon R2Tg, either in the presence or absence of several other cofactors that are either necessary for or boost performance, and demonstrating which cofactors are necessary through a single removal of each. They then ask about the construct depicted at top (blue, orange, and aquamarine bars). I explain that the 5' and 3' untranslated regions (U, blue) function as natural localization markers, and how investigators retargeted this molecule by introducing homologous arms at either end of the payload cassette (customizable region, H, orange) for them to function like an alternate untranslated region and direct the molecule elsewhere.



b. This panel examines the relative efficacy (correct integration rate) of a wild-type form, and a form with either the 5' or 3' UTR ablated. I explain the motivation for examining which reasons can be removed, how loss of the 5' UTR minorly reduces integration, but removal of the 3' UTR completely abolishes it. We then hypothesize for why this might be the case: I ask students to recall the direction in which DNA-acting enzymes (such as polymerases) run; upon receiving enough responses, I continue. Since DNA is constructed 5'-to-3' and the strands are antiparallel, the template strand is being read 3'-to-5'. Given this, a complementary interaction between DNA/RNA would be initiated by the leading edge, which would be on the 3' side of the approaching molecule. From this, it should make sense why removal of the 3' UTR abolishes proper binding.

The following are student responses pulled verbatim from Student Experiences of Teaching surveys:

This TA really knew his shit. He explained almost every concept in class competently and with clear passion and proficiency in stuff I can't even repeat to you in this review. Although I think I may drop this course due to my disappointment with my own performance, I think this TA really helped clarify the jargon in the papers and simplified the diagrams and main concepts down to main points that really stuck in my impression of the class. His explanations shaped most of my understanding, even if I myself was unable to internalize most of the knowledge. I honestly think he has been the strongest science TA I have had so far, and I hope he will TA for this class and Professor Chen again.

Christian was very helpful in explaining the papers in depth and telling us the key points. He was very friendly and made class enjoyable instead of feeling like an additional hour of just lecture content. He made it very interactive with other students by putting us in groups to discuss certain figures and then reconvening as a class to discuss further. He has definitely helped me with excelling in the class as much as possible just like the last time I had him as a TA.

Strengths: friendly, relatable, always cares about student well–being. good at communicating content efficiently. also attended lecture like all the time i think.
Weaknesses: sometimes gets off topic briefly (which can matter in the short discussion sections). sometimes not super prepared w regards to the papers, but it seems like he had a really busy few months so it's all good

Christian was a great TA. It was a lot of fun to talk to him, and I really feel like I got a lot of insight into the papers through discussion. I also felt engaged during discussion because there was more back and forth (as opposed to just lecturing on the paper). I would love to have him again as my TA :)

Christian is an amazing TA! He's very outgoing and "real", which made me feel comfortable enough to participate in discussions (and I HATE public speaking). He was also very accommodating when it came to needing to miss in person discussions by holding zoom sessions as a replacement. Everything from his teaching style to attendance form was the highlight of my week. I have no notes on weaknesses because there are none. This is literally one of the best TAs I've ever had.

It was great having you as my TA! Thank you for all of your helpful insight and explanation of concepts, I definitely learned a lot from discussion section!! Good luck with your application cycle, wishing you all the best :)

Loved the google forms we would submit every section since they were interactive and enhanced communication with the TA!

Christian was very attentive and always made sure to keep discussion interesting. The discussions matched with the course material being taught and he managed to get us to actively participate each week. He's also a very interesting person who does a lot of cool things. Overall, he was a fantastic TA!

Overall very helpful for explaining concepts and reviewing key ideas! Thank you!

Christian was such a wonderful TA to have this quarter. This is super specific but I really liked the attendance forms because it felt like he had lots of life updates to tell and he often encouraged us to do the same, and it him seem much more friendly and approachable when it came to really seeking help for questions and during office hrs. He was also very knowledgable and knew how to explain the complex papers in a way that was easy to digest and understand. I also really appreciated all of the TAs making the midterm and final slides. I think they're super helpful aswell to go over key details. The only weakness I would say would be maybe having some time saved at the end of the review sessions for like a Q&A session, but I also kind of understand given the 50 minute time constraints.

Christian is a great TA. He's very approachable and I like how when you ask questions he's extremely thoughtful about how he answers and we can really get into the papers and sort of expand on the material. I also think he's a really fair grader. Even though he just gave me a D today, he's been so fair I'm sure I deserved it. I definitely felt welcome in reaching out if I needed anything. I like the structure of section where we go over papers and do something separate instead of just recapitulating like other classes sometimes do.

cool TA, always helped out when we asked questions both in section and office hours.

Christian was an AMAZING TA; he was super welcoming and very good at making sure we had access to all the materials we needed to do well in the course. My only comment was that the background music in discussion was slightly distracting. Besides that Christian has been one of the best TAs I have had at UCLA!

This TA was knowledgeable, passionate, and understanding of students' struggles. He explains complex topics clearly and makes course material approachable.

Christian is an amazing TA! He is extremely knowledgeable of the content material, great at keeping the classroom engaged, and I can tell he just overall cares about us students and our well–being. I liked the little fun google form check–ins he has in the start of discussion section (also the light music playing in the background), and I appreciate how he simplifies content in such a way that we can understand it better (ex: analogies).

Good job

SUPER NICE! SUPER SMART! SUPER UNDERSTANDING

I appreciated how Christian talked to us more casually because it made him more approachable. His tips on how to read scientific papers was really helpful, and he was able to explain complicated figures in an understandable way.

Christian created a very welcoming environment for us to discuss difficult papers and concepts and cared about making sure everyone understood the goals and methods of the papers. I appreciated that he encouraged group discussions and asking questions, and overall felt that he wanted everyone to work together to master the course content.

He was very helpful outside of class. His office hours were very helpful, and the sections were great.

Very open and communicative about what needed to be done and explanatory about the papers we read.

Great TA, he is really good and knowledgable.

He was an amazing TA and he was very easy to talk to. He was very helpful with explaining the papers we had to read and was well prepared when reviewing content.

Christian was a great TA! He was always very knowledge and would help to break down the papers in class. I found his explanation of the figures and content of the paper to make the material much more simple and easier to apply.

Christian was a great TA! I found it very helpful that he always had us first work on analyzing the figures on our own (and asked us questions) before also giving his own explanation in detail. He did a very good job of breaking down figures into more easily explainable chunks and never made anyone feel bad if their explanation or analysis of a paper was off. I also liked that he played music at the beginning of discussion because it made it feel less awkward. He also put in a lot of effort into learning everyone's names which was very nice. He was pretty responsive over email for the most part and seemed to care about student learning. Overall a great TA!

Really good at explaining concepts

Christian was an amazing TA. He had incredible communication skills and was always able to answer any questions that I had. He did a really great job at walking us through difficult to understand research papers and walked us step by step through tricky figures that we might not have been exposed to before. His presentations were also really helpful and he made sure to always be super thorough and never took any shortcuts with us. Overall, I would definitely take another section with him again.

He is a great TA. I loved him.

They taught information that was very relevant and helpful both inside and outside the class. I found the breaking down of topics like how to read scientific articles to be integral in learning how to understand papers and think about research.

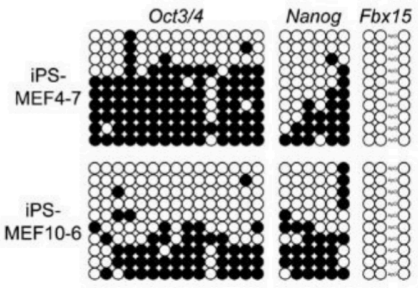
He was effective at breaking down scientific papers and presenting them in a format that made them easily digestible.

Some of the papers were difficult to understand and digest. The discussion sections were extremely helpful in digesting the papers. The TA was extremely helpful and I felt welcomed seeking help in office hours if needed.

The following images and questions are taken from MCDB 144 and MCDB 138 discussion slides, using leading questions in small group discussions in order to engage students and guide them along the proper train of thought.

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a.

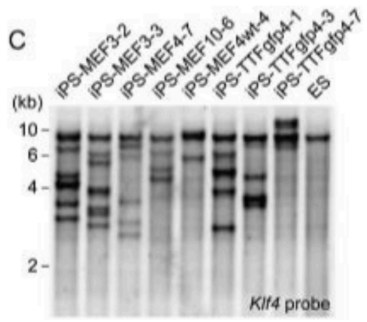


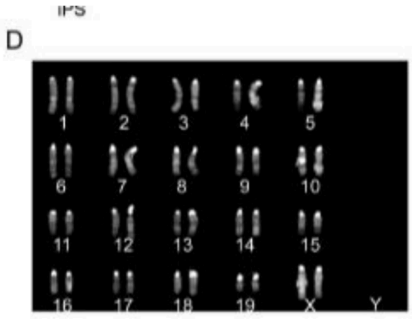
Do these clonal types seem comparable, either epigenetically or morphologically?

While this may be an epigenetic profile analysis via bisulfite sequencing, it is ultimately asking whether the top pattern matches the bottom pattern–and the clear answer to that question is “no”. Once we’ve reached that simple consensus, we can delve more deeply into the actual significance of that fact; that while these cells may appear functionally similar on the surface, their inner workings are quite different. In the context of the paper, both the top and bottom profiles are attempts to recreate an embryonic stem cell; neither of these patterns match an ESC. I used the analogy of attempting to build a car, a BMW–and at the end of it, you get a vehicle with four wheels, seats passengers, drives–but once you pop the hood you notice it’s built like a completely different car, or built with scrap parts. It may function like a car, but it is *not* a BMW, and cannot be rated to the same safety/quality (like medical implantation of these ESCs). Through these kinds of questions, we can have more in-depth conversations about why this kind of data analysis is important while encouraging student participation and independent thinking.

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b.





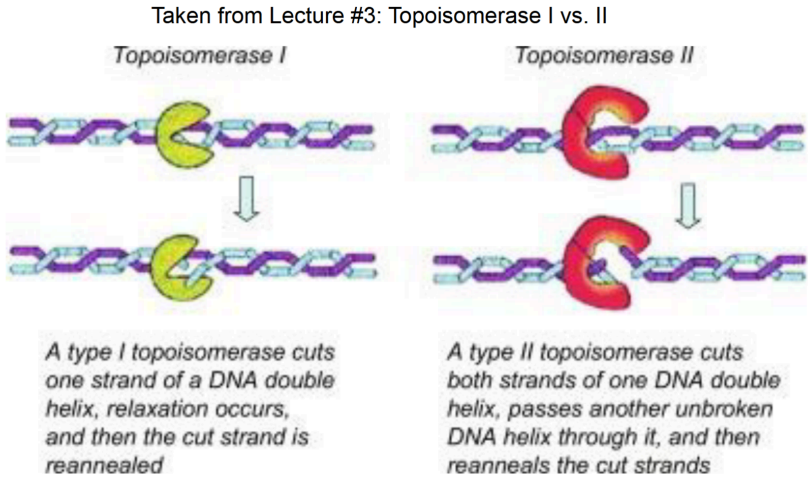
How do the iPSC bands on this Klf4 Southern blot compare to a normal ESC? What are the biological implications of these band patterns? What about the karyotype– does it appear normal?

This figure is taken from the same paper, again asking students (within their groups) to identify visual differences and speculate on their consequences. Again, we can take these simple observations and expand on them, bringing these data from “bands and bumps” to real indicators of human disease. I ask how many copies we should have of a particular gene as diploid organisms, assuming the base number is one copy. They say, “two”. I ask how many appear in the blots at left, they answer (several). I ask about the implications; they think, and answer that these off-target additional copies must be interrupting other necessary genes all throughout the genome; students then grasp *why* these cells appear both morphologically and epigenetically abnormal. I always emphasize what is this figure *really*

telling us, and *why is it significant?*

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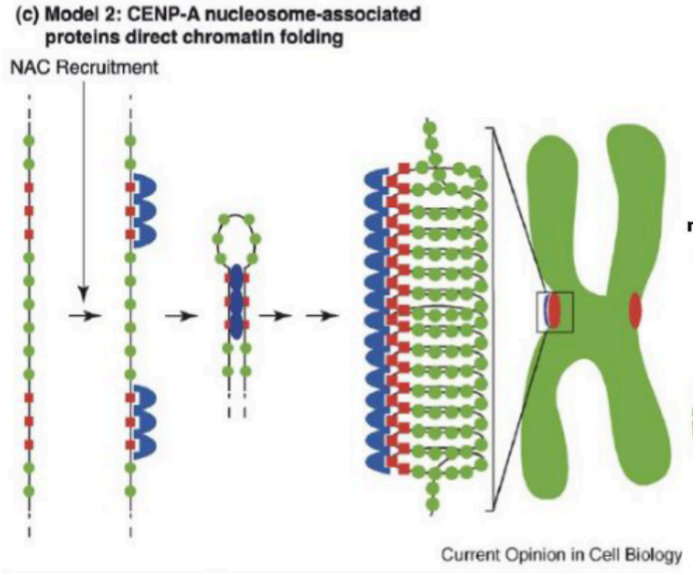
c.



One of several review slides made prior to midterms or finals. I always made sure to reinforce conceptual logic and function over rote memorization, because once the logic is grasped, memorization becomes unnecessary. In this slide, I demonstrate T1 vs TII using my computer charger cable. T1 functions on *one* DNA strand. I take my charger cable and twist it until it coils, then disconnect the midpoint at the battery pack, relieve tension, and reconnect the cable. “TII functions on *two* DNA strands,” I say. I then fold my computer cable so that two ends are perpendicular and show how the two are tangled; then I disconnect the midpiece once again, pass the second segment through, and reconnect the midpoint, which undoes the knot. I explain how topoisomerases function in the same way to relieve DNA tension; and since we’ve covered DNA repair and briefly touched on mutations/cancer by this point, I have students speculate on the consequences of frequent DNA breakages. Students grasp the underlying logic and function, and no longer have to rely on memorization.

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d.

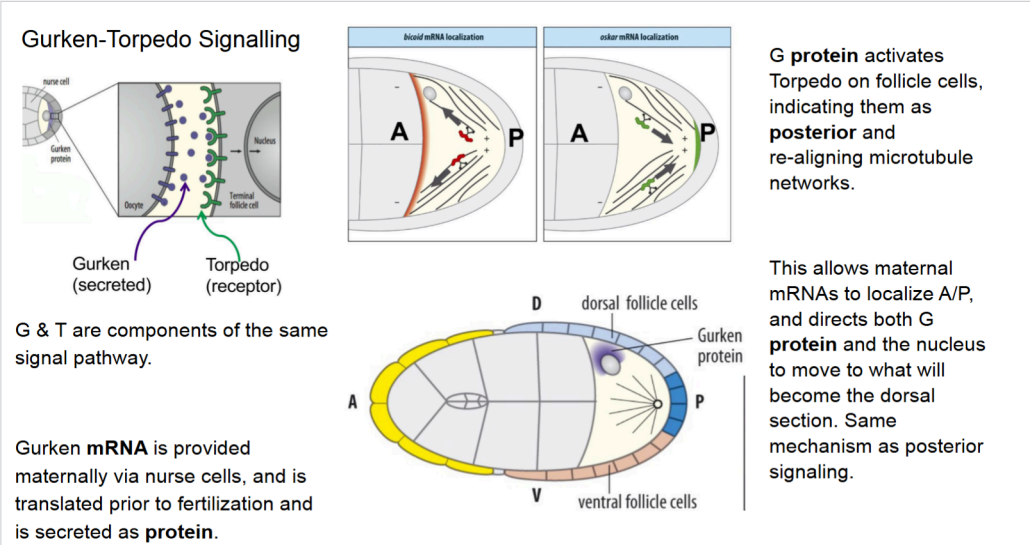


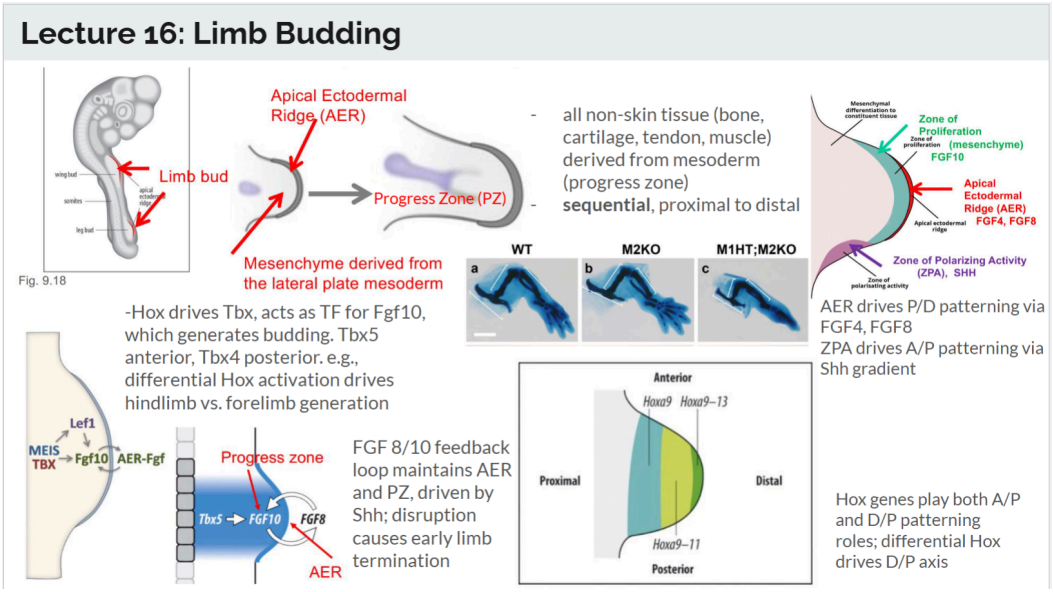
I make sure to connect new concepts with prior knowledge whenever possible, to integrate content as a full network and not a linear chain. In this case, we very frequently talk about structure dictating function, especially in regards to proteins or etc.; we also discuss the three-dimensionality of DNA condensation. In this context, I point out how the ring-like condensation of DNA requires macroscopic chromosomal features (such as the kinetochore site) to be organized in a regularly interspaced fashion (along the linear sequence) to align properly once condensed. Points such as these emphasize why proper arrangement is

so necessary and why seemingly minor conformational changes introduced via mutagens can have significant impacts.

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e.





Content review sessions contain highly condensed but intuitively structured lectures which begin with the core phenomena, then explain the function/purpose/logic, then lastly the mechanism to accomplish such. Condensed slides are very useful for rapid yet comprehensive review, and are particularly effective at eliminating mix-ups, as each piece of the process is laid out in its proper place and the connections between them are explained in detail. At bottom, limb anatomy development is shown, explained to occur in a stepwise fashion in independent segments, proximal to distal, and adjacent are images of truncated limb development showing how one segment can be disrupted without affecting any others. Especially for signalling phenomena (above), the similarities between these and other related mechanisms are always emphasized (i.e. this works in the same way as ___), allowing students to draw common connections.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

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Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

Christian was my teaching assistant for MCDB 144 during the Summer 2025 session. I had the pleasure of learning from him as he guided me throughout the course. He consistently took initiative to support student learning beyond scheduled lectures and discussion sections.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

As a teaching assistant for a cellular biology course, Christian inspired curiosity and deeper engagement with the scientific process. He consistently encouraged students to think beyond memorization, challenging us to understand the purpose, design, and intent behind key questions and experiments. He introduced landmark experiments in cell biology, and by doing so, he helped connect foundational concepts to the broader narrative of scientific discovery.

Christian also fostered an inclusive learning environment, which made me appreciate the fact anyone regardless of background or experience, can engage in science. His approach made complex material accessible and emphasized that anyone can learn to appreciate the beauty and rigor of science through curiosity and critical thinking.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

One thing Christian did that was especially helpful was pushing us to think about why experiments were designed the way they were, not just what the results showed. During discussions, he would slow things down and talk through the reasoning behind controls, methods, and conclusions, which made the material feel much more intuitive and less overwhelming.

He was also approachable and genuinely invested in helping students succeed. Christian regularly made time outside of class to answer questions and clarify confusing topics, and he explained concepts in ways that matched each student's background. His patience and enthusiasm made it easier to engage with challenging material and helped many of us build confidence in understanding cellular biology.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Christian was truly one of the best TAs I have had at UCLA, and he made my summer learning experience especially memorable. What set him apart was how intentional he was about including every student. He consistently paused to ask if we had questions, creating space for even the shyest students to speak up and feel heard. His patience and genuine care for student learning made the class feel supportive and engaging. Christian's dedication went beyond teaching content; he made students feel confident and excited to learn.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name Ashwin Katta

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

Christian was my TA for MCD BIO 144, an upper division developmental biology course. I saw him on a weekly basis and learned a lot from his discussion sections.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

The method of teaching Christian employed was phenomenal in the sense his guiding questions as we dissected research papers were quite thought-provoking and nuanced. This allowed our discussion sections to have quite intellectual conversations and discuss concepts beyond the paper, solidifying our knowledge of course concepts further. The way he taught us using external figures he would search up really showcased his passion for the course content and his teaching methods are what I adopted as I began teaching as a Learning Assistant for other courses. He really cared if we understood concepts, encouraged us to ask questions, and was quite receptive to student feedback.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Christian would often go through lecture slides and explain concepts in a way I considered arguably better than the professor, where he would go into depth about course concepts and their importance. He would also provide thoughtful answers to his own questions after asking them, building off of what students mentioned. There is a very creative aspect in terms of experimental design for this course, so he did a really good job enabling us to understand the various avenues we could take in designing an experiment and fostering our competence in understanding papers.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Christian really goes above and beyond for his students, providing valuable tips for success in the course and gauging student understanding as he adapts his teaching methods. He has been such a great help to me throughout the quarter and has been an amazing mentor beyond the course. I can wholeheartedly say he is the best TA I have ever had at UCLA, and his commitment to his students really highlights this.

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January 31, 2026

Diana Rigueur
801 Hilgard Avenue
Hershey Hall 312
Los Angeles, Ca, 90095
drigueur@ucla.edu

Dear Distinguished Teaching Committee,

It is with great pleasure that I write this letter of support for Mr. Christian Gerard Capuno for the Distinguished Teaching Award, in the category for Teaching Assistants.

I am a Distinguished Assistant Researcher and Lecturer with dual appointments with the department of Molecular, Cell & Developmental Biology and the Biomedical Research Minor. Christian was an extremely driven and creative Teaching Assistant in my upper division course MCDB 144 Molecular Biology during the Spring and Summer of 2025.

I am writing this letter of recommendation for Christian because out of all the TA's I've trained, he was by far the most organized. He was also a self-starter and went above and beyond to ensure clarity in his teaching. Christian was an exceptional TA. He also TA'd for my colleague, Dr. Jau-nian Chen for MCDB 138, Developmental Biology, a very difficult course. Christian asked to audit my Developmental Biology 138 course during the summer so that he could execute his TA-ship with proficiency, an example of his devotion to his craft.

Christian Gerard is an exceptional TA. I hope his efforts are recognized in this letter and his other materials. If there are any questions, feel free to contact me at any time via email or call my office at (310) 794-9489, or preferably due to COVID, my personal home line at (714) 603-9930.

Sincerely,

Diana Rigueur

Diana Rigueur, PhD
Molecular Cell & Developmental Biology Faculty
University of California, Los Angeles